



costs,” says Aditya Welekar, Research Analyst at Axis Securities. For most of the manufacturers, the lower-end diesel vehicles are near the end of their product life cycle, he explains. “These companies think setting up new infrastructure and bearing the cost is not justified. The cost of vehicle acquisition is also going to increase,” he says, adding that these emission norms are pushing the carmakers towards hybrid and electric vehicles (EV). “It is indirectly an incentive for them. Diesel powertrains will not be as popular as before. They will be more prominent in the higher SUV segment. Maybe hybrid will be the new diesel,” he adds. Experts say that prices of vehicles are expected to increase by at least ₹15,000-20,000.

Per M.R. Singhania, President of Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations, EVs are expected to push the growth for the industry going forward. “The government is serious about EV adoption, and we will see carmakers moving towards EVs soon,” he says. **BT**

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the regulatory certainty that the rules for online games will provide will surely provide a fillip in terms of investor sentiment,” says Roland Landers, CEO of industry body All India Gaming Federation.

Some of the key proposals include setting up one or more self-regulatory bodies for the industry, mandatory KYC of players as per Reserve Bank of India norms as well as setting up a grievance redressal mechanism. As the compliance obligations proposed in the rules are largely in line with industry best practices, many gaming companies are already following them. Industry body E-Gaming Federation (EGF), for instance, has established a self-regulatory standard in the form of a Code of Conduct involving KYC, SSL-level encryption, RNG certification, and other risk-flagging mechanisms to protect players. Its CEO Sameer Barde says they also mandate audits by the Big Four audit firms periodically. “Moreover, our flagship ‘Responsible Play’ model involves meeting requirements that ensure assisting vulnerable players, protecting player data, ensuring secure payments, and maintaining

GAME ON!

Some of the key proposals

▶ **The online gaming industry is required to have one or more self-regulatory bodies with a five-member board of directors from diverse fields**

▶ **They can only register games that do not contain “anything which is not in the interest of sovereignty and integrity of India, defence of India, security of the state, friendly relations with foreign states or public order”**

▶ **Gaming firms have to ensure mandatory KYC verification of players based on RBI norms, transparent withdrawal and refund of money and a fair distribution of winnings, among others**

▶ **Firms have to evolve a framework to safeguard children, protect users against the risk of gaming addiction and financial loss as well as financial frauds**

responsible marketing.”

The norms will only introduce a well-defined uniform regime across the ecosystem and bring in more safety and transparency for players, the experts say. Though the compliance burden may not be high, there are challenges for gaming companies in the form of age-gating and verification of players by self-regulatory bodies, implementing KYC mechanisms at RBI-mandated levels for small-value customer accounts and satisfying customer grievances and law enforcement requests within an aggressive time frame, says Arun Prabhu, Partner & Head-Technology Media Telecom, Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas. “Creating, obtaining and maintaining registrations for games with the self-regulatory bodies, especially if there are numerous applicants for such registrations, will also be a challenge,” he adds.

While the challenges persist, the industry and the other stakeholders feel that the government’s move is a step in the right direction. **BT**

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